



Words matter: The impact of workplace verbal aggressiveness on workgroup relationship conflict, work-life conflict, and employee-organization relationships

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ABSTRACT

Workplace verbal aggressiveness is detrimental to employees and organizations and is perceived as unwanted and unproductive. This study examined whether and how verbal aggressiveness from supervisors and coworkers influences workgroup relationship conflict, employees' work-life conflict, and employee-organization relationships. An online survey was conducted with 392 full-time employees in the United States. The key findings of this study showed that when verbal aggressiveness abounds in a workgroup, it creates workgroup relationship conflict, which triggers individual employees' work-life conflict and tarnishes their trust, satisfaction, commitment, and sense of shared power with their organizations.

The COVID-19 pandemic has brought work-life conflict, teleworking, and internal communication to the forefront for employees and employers worldwide (Leroy et al., 2021; Shockley et al., 2021; Yue & Walden, 2022). In this context, effective communication with internal stakeholders has become increasingly vital for organizations and leaders. Research by public relations scholars has advanced our understanding of the internal communication factors that lead to engaged and satisfied employees and quality employee-organization relationships, with substantial evidence highlighting the crucial role of symmetrical, transparent, dialogic, and empathetic communication (e.g., Jiang & Men, 2017; Kang & Sung, 2017; Kim, 2018; Lee & Li, 2020; Li et al., 2021; Men, 2014; Walden et al., 2017; Yue et al., 2022). However, negative internal communication and its detrimental effects on employees and organizations have received limited attention. In light of this, the current study, grounded in literature on relationship management and internal communication, delves into the dark side of internal communication by investigating the impact of workplace verbal aggressiveness on employee-organization relationship quality.

Incidents of bullying, including verbal aggressiveness, are prevalent in professional settings (Namie & Lutgen-Sandvik, 2010). A recent study indicates that 30% of adult Americans have directly experienced bullying, and 49% have been affected as either a target or a witness (Namie, 2021). Verbal aggressiveness, in the form of name-calling,

vulgar language, demeaning remarks, gaslighting, and threats, is often displayed by supervisors and coworkers, and it is considered a type of workplace bullying (Namie, 2021).

It's important to note that destructive internal communication, such as verbal aggressiveness, should not be equated with a lack of exemplary communication practices. Rather, it represents the opposite of exemplary communication and should be treated as a distinct behavioral construct. To the best of the authors' knowledge, no previous empirical studies have investigated the detrimental impact of destructive communication on employee-organization relationship building and the process through which it occurs.

This study builds a conceptual model that connects workplace verbal aggressiveness, two types of conflict (workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict), and employee-organization relationships. Drawing on spillover and conservation of resource theories, this study posits that employees' negative work experience (i.e., workplace verbal aggressiveness, workgroup relationship conflict) will spill over to their personal lives, depleting the resources necessary for them to invest in their familial domain, resulting in work-life conflict. Additionally, based on the principles of social exchange and reciprocity, the study suggests that employees will perceive a lower quality of relationship with their organization if they experience high levels of both work-life conflict and workgroup relationship conflict.

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1. Literature review

The literature review begins by providing an overview of the research on verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict, and then delves into the relationship between the two variables. This is followed by an examination of work-life conflict, including a theoretical explanation of its connection to verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict. The review concludes by exploring employee-organization relationships and how they are affected by workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict.

1.1. Verbal aggressiveness

Verbal aggressiveness is defined as “the tendency to attack the self-concepts of individuals instead of, or in addition to, their positions on topics of communication” (Infante, 1987, p. 164). This behavior often belittles, insults, and derides others, and is intended to inflict psychological pain on the other person (Hamilton & Hample, 2011; Infante, 1995; Infante & Wigley, 1986). Attacks can range from questioning someone’s competence and character to targeting their physical appearance and background. Verbal aggressiveness can take the form of overt methods such as ridicule, profanity, maledictions, and threats, as well as more subtle techniques such as gaslighting and repeatedly correcting and humiliating someone (Infante & Rancer, 1996).

Scholars have proposed different theories on the origins of verbal aggressiveness. Some argue that it is a learned behavior acquired through socialization, while others suggest it is a biologically determined trait with minimal influence from external factors (Infante & Rancer, 1996). Despite the differing perspectives, it is widely acknowledged that verbal aggressiveness can have negative consequences, such as creating a hostile work environment and promoting defensiveness (Anderson & Martin, 1999; Lin et al., 2017; Rancer & Avtgis, 2014; Sollitto & Cranmer, 2019).

The detrimental effects of verbal aggression are far-reaching and can include self-concept damage, aggression escalation, and relationship deterioration (Infante, 1995). Employees who experience verbal aggression are at an increased risk of experiencing anxiety, depression, and physical health declines (Chory et al., 2020; Spector et al., 2007). Verbal aggression from supervisors, in particular, can have a profound impact on subordinates. A study by Madlock and Kennedy-Ligthsey (2010) found that subordinates’ organizational commitment, job satisfaction, and communication satisfaction are significantly more negatively affected by supervisors’ verbal aggression than by positive communicative behaviors from supervisors, such as mentoring. Despite the fact that most cases of workplace bullying are perpetrated by individuals with a higher rank than their targets (Namie, 2021), verbal aggression and bullying among coworkers is also prevalent. The Workplace Bullying Institute found that many perpetrators of bullying are peers with the same rank as their targets (Namie, 2021).

1.2. Workgroup relationship conflict

Group conflict has been extensively studied in the field of organizational studies (Solansky et al., 2014). Conflict, which refers to perceived differences and incompatibilities among the involved parties (de Wit et al., 2012), is characterized by friction, frustration, and interpersonal clashes (Jehn, 1995). Within work groups, group conflict is generally divided into two categories: task conflict and relationship conflict (Jehn, 1997; Jehn et al., 1999). Task conflict centers around intellectual opposition related to the content, perspectives, and outcomes of the task (Desivilya et al., 2010; Jehn, 1995) while relationship conflict arises from interpersonal disagreements that are not directly related to the task (de Wit et al., 2012; Solansky et al., 2014). To put it simply, task conflict concerns the task itself, while relationship conflict is centered around personal issues of dislike. As this study aims to examine the relational impact of verbal aggressiveness, we have chosen

to focus on relationship conflict rather than task conflict.

As Jehn and colleagues (1999) have noted, relationship conflict refers to “conflict over work group members’ personal preferences or disagreements about interpersonal interactions” (p. 745). These relational incompatibilities often manifest as animosity, annoyance, interpersonal emotional tension, and dislike among members (Desivilya et al., 2010). Research in the area of group conflict has shown that relationship conflict can inhibit cognitive functioning (Roseman et al., 1994) and distract members from the task at hand (Wilson et al., 1986), ultimately leading to lower levels of individual and group efficacy, performance, and functioning (Jehn, 1995; Solansky et al., 2014). In the presence of workgroup relationship conflict, there may be rude interpersonal clashes and a lack of consideration for fellow group members, negatively impacting group members’ compliance, cooperation, and helping behavior (De Dreu & Van Vianen, 2001). Rispens and colleagues (2011) suggest that the negative effects of relationship conflict on group functioning can be attributed to two main reasons. Firstly, relationship conflicts within work groups lead to a wide range of negative emotions and outbursts (Jehn & Bendersky, 2003). Secondly, relationship conflicts impact constructive group processes, resulting in reduced intra-group trust and increased dissatisfaction (De Dreu & Weingart, 2003). Research suggests that relationship conflict can be influenced by factors such as intrapersonal diversity (e.g., gender, ethnicity, age, personality), uncertain project tasks (e.g., requirement uncertainty, time urgency, risk allocation), organizational culture diversity (e.g., regulations or codes, display rules), and inappropriate behavior (e.g., abusive supervision, criticism, poor communication) (Huo et al., 2016).

1.3. Work-life conflict

Conflict between work and life refers to the extent to which participating in one role makes it more difficult to participate in the other role due to the distinct norms and requirements of each role (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985). When these conflicts arise, the pressures from each domain become increasingly incompatible. Conflict between work and life can occur in two directions. Work-to-life conflict occurs when work interferes with the non-work domain (e.g., working on weekends or bringing negative emotions home), while life-to-work conflict arises when non-work obligations prevent employees from fulfilling their work expectations (e.g., caring for a sick child or elderly family member) (Denker & Dougherty, 2013). The current study focuses on work-to-life conflict.

Time, energy, and commitment are necessary to adequately perform work and non-work roles. As a result, three types of sources of work-life conflict have been identified: time-based, strain-based, and behavior-based (Greenhaus & Beutell, 1985). Time-based conflict occurs when the amount of time spent in one role affects the performance of another role. Studies have found that compulsory overtime, unpredictable working schedules, and working at nonstandard times can lead to time-based work-life conflict (Scott et al., 2005). Strain-based conflict occurs when the fatigue or strain experienced in one role diminishes the resources that would otherwise be available for another role. Greenhaus and Beutell (1985) noted that several work stressors (e.g., role ambiguity, work conflict) that lead to psychological or physical strain are independent of time-based work demands. Finally, behavior-based conflict occurs when the behavioral styles expected in one role are incompatible with those expected in another role. For example, family members may expect warmth and affection from an individual whose role at work requires aggressiveness and assertiveness (Keeney et al., 2013). Studies have shown that these three types of conflict are separate but interconnected concepts (Byron, 2005).

While it is valuable to examine all forms of work-life conflict, it is not uncommon for researchers to focus on a specific form of work-life conflict (e.g., Bakker et al., 2008; Jiang, 2012). This approach allows for the identification of unique antecedents of different types of work-life conflict. In this study, we chose to focus on strain-based conflict as it

captures the transported symptoms (e.g., anxiety, irritability) from one domain to the other, which corresponds to the antecedents (i.e., verbal aggressiveness, workgroup relationship conflict) proposed in the study.

Research has found that various factors impact work-life conflict, including organizational factors, family-related factors, and individual factors (Michel et al., 2011). The current study focuses on organization-related stressors of work-life conflict, specifically workplace verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict. Regarding the effect of work-family conflict, previous research has consistently shown that work-life conflict functions as a stressor that hampers employee job satisfaction, organizational commitment, and work engagement (Liao, 2011; Siegel et al., 2005; Yue, 2022). To expand on this line of research, the current study explores the impact of work-family conflict on employee-organization relationship quality.

1.4. The impact of verbal aggressiveness on workgroup relationship conflict

The current study aimed to examine the impact of supervisors' and coworkers' verbal aggressiveness on workgroup relationship conflict. While there is limited research on the specific link between supervisor verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict, previous studies have identified the negative impact of verbal aggressiveness on various work-related outcomes. For example, verbal aggressiveness decreases subordinates' perceptions of their supervisor's credibility or competence (Lybarger et al., 2017). A study by Sollitto and Cranmer (2019) found that supervisor verbal aggressiveness is negatively associated with followers' acculturation, involvement, and familiarity with coworkers and supervisors. Furthermore, supervisor verbal aggressiveness can lead employees to leave the organization or consider other career options (Madlock & Dillow, 2012).

Given that supervisor verbal aggressiveness can make it difficult for subordinates to assimilate into the organization or trust their supervisor, it is plausible that it may also increase perceptions of relationship conflicts within the workgroup. Additionally, the trickle-down effect of leader behavior can explain the spread of dysfunctional intra-organizational behavior. Research shows that employees model not only positive but also negative leader behavior (Liu et al., 2012). When supervisors engage in frequent verbal attacks on group members without facing consequences, subordinates may perceive this behavior as socially acceptable and engage in social learning and imitation (Bandura, 1973). This can lead to increased interpersonal tensions and workgroup relationship conflict. In light of the preceding logic and empirical evidence, the current study proposes the following hypothesis:

H1. Supervisor verbal aggressiveness is positively related to perceived relationship conflict in the working group.

The verbally aggressive behaviors (e.g., rebuff, ridicule, and profanity) initiated by coworkers will also likely cause misunderstanding, humiliation, resentment, and friction, which is the root of relationship conflict (Huo et al., 2016). Studies have found that negative forms of communication among coworkers, such as gossiping and complaining, decrease employees' job satisfaction and organizational commitment (Fay & Kline, 2011). Additionally, employees with high levels of verbal aggressiveness tend to engage in more complaining behavior and non-collaborative strategies (Avtgis & Rancer, 2008) and report lower levels of group cohesion and dependability (Anderson & Martin, 1999; Harris, 1997). Following this line of empirical evidence, the following prediction is made:

H2. Coworker verbal aggressiveness is positively related to perceived relationship conflict in the working group.

1.5. The antecedents of work-life conflict: verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict

Based on the foundation of spillover theory (Staines, 1980) and the conservation of resources (COR) theory (Hobfoll, 1989), the current

study argues that the negative effects of verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict will likely spill over to employees' life domain, deplete their emotional resources that can be allotted to the family domain, and eventually increase perceptions of work-life conflict.

First, the spillover theory posits that despite the physical and temporal boundaries that often exist between work and life, the feelings, attitudes, and behaviors experienced by an individual can spill over from one role to the other (Staines, 1980). Scholars have used spillover theory to explain the impact that job demands have on work-life conflict (Eby et al., 2005). For example, research indicates that abusive supervision leads to spillover in subordinates' family lives, resulting in work-life conflict (Tepper, 2000). When subordinates who experience abuse leave the workplace, they may displace their aggression and engage in behaviors that their family members perceive as undermining the family (Hoobler & Brass, 2006; Valle et al., 2021). Specifically, we expect that verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict will most directly affect the strain-based form of work-life conflict, a type of conflict that leaves employees feeling stressed, frazzled, frustrated, and unable to fulfill commitments in their non-work roles. Bakker et al. (2008) identified emotional demands and work overload to be key determinants of strain-based work-life conflict.

In addition to spillover theory, COR theory further illustrates the process through which verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict induce work-life conflict. The basic tenet of COR theory is that people are motivated to protect their current resources and acquire new resources. When resource loss occurs, stress and emotional exhaustion will follow. Resources are defined as "anything perceived by the individual to help attain his or her goal" (Halbesleben et al., 2014, p. 1338). A significant number of empirical studies have found that when employees lose resources at work, they are more likely to experience burnout, depression, and emotional exhaustion (Hobfoll, 1989; 2001).

Previous research has used COR theory to explain why abusive situations at work can trigger the depletion of resources and cause work-life conflict (Valle et al., 2021). When employees are repeatedly exposed to verbal aggressiveness, they become more aware of the fact that they are not experiencing positive relationships. This awareness can lead to higher utilization of emotional energy and resources to cope with workplace verbal aggressiveness, creating a downward spiral of resource depletion (Hobfoll, 2001). This negatively impacts employees' family lives because it reduces the amount of cognitive and emotional resources available to employees to regulate their behaviors and be their "best self" at home (Witt & Carlson, 2006). In summary, spillover theory explains that stress can be transmitted from one domain to another domain, and COR further unpacks the path by which it occurs (i.e., through resource loss), making both theories proper theoretical platforms to explain the impact of verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict on employee work-life conflict.

Research investigating the impact of verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict on work-life conflict is limited, but some preliminary evidence exists. Previous studies have found that employees who experience stress and negative social interactions at work are more likely to engage in aggressive behavior and social undermining at home (Repetti et al., 2009; Story & Repetti, 2006). Additionally, abusive supervision has been linked to increased perceptions of work-family conflict, burnout (Carlson et al., 2012; Valle et al., 2021) and psychological distress (Restubog et al., 2011).

Drawing on the spillover and COR theories and supporting empirical research, we posit that verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict can cause emotional harm and resource depletion, resulting in negative spillover effects on employees' personal lives and increased work-to-life conflict. Hence, the following hypotheses are proposed:

H3: Perceived workgroup relationship conflict is positively related to work-life conflict.

H4: Supervisor verbal aggressiveness is positively related to work-life conflict.

H5: Coworker verbal aggressiveness is positively related to work-life

conflict.

1.6. Employee-organization relationships

Organization-public relationships are often referred to as one of the major outcomes of public relations (Ledingham & Bruning, 2000; Seltzer & Zhang, 2011). Given the influence that workers have on the financial performance and reputation of their organizations, developing high-quality employee-organization relationships (EORs) is a critical aspect of internal public relations (Lee & Yue, 2020; Men & Bowen, 2017; Shen & Jiang, 2022). EORs are defined as the extent to which “an organization and its employees trust one another, agree on who has the rightful power to influence, experience satisfaction with each other, and commit themselves to the other” (Men, 2014, p. 261). This definition highlights four relational outcomes representing the quality of the relationship between employees and the organization: trust, control mutuality, satisfaction, and commitment (Grunig & Huang, 2000).

Given the significant impact that strong employee-organization relationships (EORs) have on employees and the overall success of an organization (Kang & Sung, 2017; Yue et al., 2022), there have been numerous studies that have examined the factors that contribute to high-quality EORs. These studies suggest that effective communication strategies, such as symmetrical, empathetic, and transparent communication (Lee & Li, 2020; Li et al., 2021; Men, 2014; Yue et al., 2022) and authentic and transformational leadership (Jiang, 2012; Kang & Sung, 2017; Men, 2014), foster strong EORs.

Previous research in internal public relations has primarily focused on identifying positive organizational factors that contribute to high-quality EORs. However, the current study aims to identify factors that hinder the formation of quality EORs. Specifically, the study examines the negative impact of workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict on EORs. The following section provides justification for the proposed hypotheses.

1.7. The antecedent of EORs: work-life conflict and workgroup relationship conflict

Scholars have argued that the negative impact of work-life conflict on employees' work attitudes and behaviors can be explained by the Social Exchange Theory (SET) (Liao, 2011; Siegel et al., 2005). SET is based on the principle of mutual obligations and reciprocity, which states that individuals will give back commensurately what they perceive to have received (or failed to have received) from another party in an exchange relationship (Eisenberger et al., 1997; Gouldner, 1960; Mitchell & Ambrose, 2007). Reciprocity of socio-emotional resources is one of the main aspects of social exchanges. Research indicates that when employees face the possibility of their work interfering with their family life, they tend to attribute this negative experience to the organization not treating them properly or caring about their well-being, and therefore reciprocate by becoming less committed to the organization (Liao, 2011; Siegel et al., 2005). In addition, current empirical literature supports a negative relationship between work-family conflict and job satisfaction (Gordon et al., 2007; Wright et al., 2014). That is, when employees view work-family conflict as a source of frustration and an indicator of unfavorable treatment, their job satisfaction level decreases (Haar, 2008; Siegel et al., 2005) and they tend to withdraw from the work in an attempt to eliminate the conflict (Kossek & Ozeki, 1999). Jiang's (2012) investigation on the relationship between work-family conflict and EOR quality also confirmed that time-based work-life conflict decreases EOR quality.

Based on SET and previous research, it is reasonable to assume that when employees perceive that the source of their work-life conflict is a result of negative experiences within the workplace, they are more likely to reciprocate the organization with low levels of trust, satisfaction, and commitment. This theoretical relationship has some empirical support. As shown by previous studies, when work negatively interferes with

employees' personal lives, it often leads to decreased feelings of organizational attachment (Kossek & Ozeki, 1999).

H6: Work-life conflict is negatively related to employee-organization relationships.

Research on work group cohesiveness has found that it has positive effects on employees' organizational commitment, satisfaction, and goodwill towards the organization, such as protecting the organization against potential threats (George & Brief, 1992; Griffith, 1988). In contrast, employees who experience loneliness in their work groups have reduced their affective commitment to the organization (Ozcelik & Barsade, 2018). The link between employees' experiences within their work group and their perceptions and relationships with the organization is succinctly summarized by Ozcelik and Barsade: “people generalize from their smaller dyadic or group-level exchanges to the broader group” and will project the responsibility for their current negative group-level experience onto the broader organization (2018, p. 2348). Therefore, when relationship conflict becomes the norm in employees' work groups, it hinders employees from developing high-quality relationships with the organization. We suggest the following hypothesis:

H7: Perceived workgroup relationship conflict is negatively related to employee-organization relationships.

Fig. 1 shows the conceptual model of the study.

2. Method

2.1. Participants and procedures

To test the conceptual model, an online survey was administered on Qualtrics in September 2021. The study was approved by the Institutional Review Board before data collection. Participants were recruited through Prime Panels, a participant-sourcing platform for online research and surveys that aggregates several market research panels. Prime Panels enables data collection with samples that are more representative of the U.S. population, compared to microtask sites like MTurk (Chandler et al., 2019) and applies a vetting procedure to prevent respondents who provide low-quality data from entering a study (Chandler et al., 2019).

The sample for this study was selected using specific criteria such as full-time employees working in medium and large-sized U.S. organizations with at least 50 employees in major industries according to the Bureau of Labor Statistics of the U.S. Department of Labor. Quota sampling was employed to ensure that the participants' age, gender, race, and ethnicity are proportionate to the general population according to the US census. Finally, a screening question was applied at the beginning of the survey to ensure that the participants work in a team of more than two people at the time the survey was taken.

In total, 440 participants completed the survey. However, 48 participants were removed from the analysis as they selected “I don't know” on key questions measuring workplace verbal aggressiveness. Therefore, the final sample comprised 392 full-time employees working in various industries and organizations in the U.S. They had an average age of 46 years old. The sample was comprised of 51.8% females, 47.2% males, and 1% identified as other. Most participants had a bachelor's degree (30.6%), followed by some college (21.9%) and a master's degree (21.4%). More than half of the participants were in a non-management position (52%). Table 1 summarizes the participants' demographic information.

2.2. Measurement

The key measurement items in the present study were adopted from established scales. Five-point Likert scale from 1 (strongly disagree/almost never true) to 5 (strongly agree/almost always true) was employed to measure the key constructs. Table 2 showed the bivariate correlations, means, and standard deviations of the main variables.

Supervisors' use of verbal aggressiveness ($\alpha = .95$) was measured using

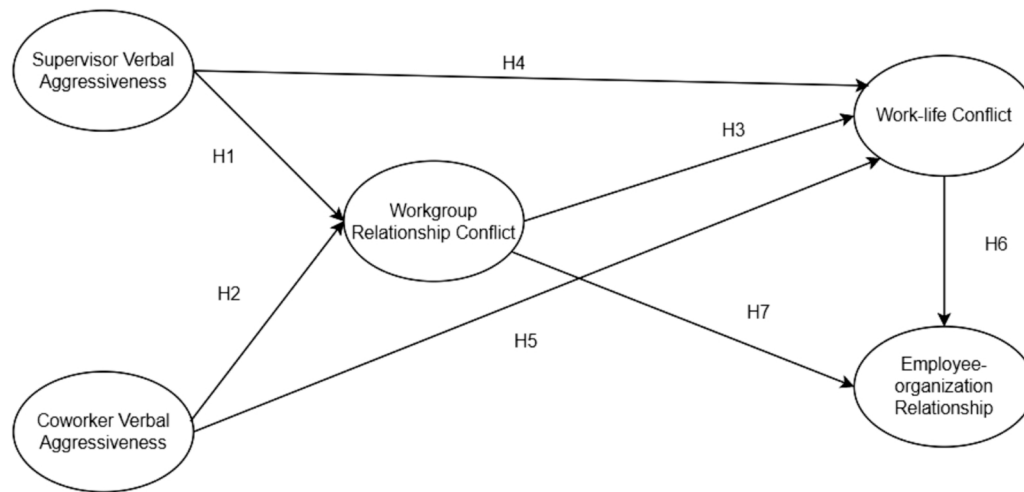


Fig. 1. The conceptual model.

selected five items from Infante and Wigley's (1986) Verbal Aggressiveness Scale. A sample item included "When individuals are very stubborn, my supervisor uses insults to soften their stubbornness."

Coworkers' use of verbal aggressiveness ($\alpha = .94$) was measured with the same five items from the Verbal Aggressiveness Scale (Infante & Wigley, 1986) with slight modifications. An example is "When people simply will not budge on a matter of importance, my coworkers lose temper and say rather strong things to them."

Workgroup relationship conflict ($\alpha = .95$) was borrowed from Jehn (1995) (four items, e.g., "There is a lot of friction among employees in my department").

Employee-organization relationships ($\alpha = .96$) were measured with 16 items containing four sub-dimensions (e.g., "My organization can be relied on to keep its promises," "I am happy with my organization") (Men & Bowen, 2017).

Work-life conflict ($\alpha = .91$) comprised three items from Carlson et al. (2000), focusing on strain-based work interference with life (e.g., "Due to all the pressures at work, sometimes when I come home I am too stressed to do the things I enjoy").

2.3. Analysis

The hypothesis testing in this study involves establishing relationships between multidimensional latent constructs. Structural Equation Modeling (SEM), a causal inference method, was employed for data analysis. In accordance with the two-step modeling approach proposed by Anderson and Gerbing (1988), the measurement model was first assessed before testing the structural model. To evaluate the goodness-of-fit of the data-model, this study adopted the joint criteria proposed by Hu & Bentler (1999) which includes either a Comparative Fit Index (CFI) $\geq .96$ and a Standardized Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR) ≤ 1.0 , or a Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA) $\leq .06$ and a Standardized Root Mean Square Residual (SRMR) $\leq .08$.

A potential concern when collecting data from the same participants at the same time through self-reported surveys is the presence of common method variance (Podsakoff & Organ, 1986). To examine this, Harman's (1960) approach was employed in this study. All factor items were loaded into one common factor and the results indicated that the total variance for a single factor was 36.93%, which is less than 50%. Therefore, it can be concluded that common method variance is not a serious threat in this study.

3. Results

3.1. Confirmatory factor analysis

A confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) was conducted by allowing all the latent constructs to covary. The measurement model yielded a good fit to the data: $\chi^2(481) = 1100.649$, $p < .001$; CFI = .953; TLI = .949; RMSEA = .057, 90% CI [.053, .062], $p < .01$; SRMR = .068.

We further tested the model's convergent validity, discriminant validity, and composite reliability (see Table 2). Convergent validity was established as all factor loadings were significant at the $p < .001$ level and all AVE scores were above the minimum threshold of .50 (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Discriminant validity was also confirmed as all square roots of AVEs were larger than the correlation between the construct and any others (Fornell & Larcker, 1981). Finally, composite reliabilities ranged from .91 to .97, which is above the minimum threshold of .70 (Hair et al., 2009). Table 3 presented the CFA results.

3.2. Control variables

Becker et al. (2016) recommended that researchers conduct analyses, including SEM, with and without control variables to determine their impact on the relationships between independent and dependent variables. If the control variables do not significantly affect the results, a more parsimonious model without controls should be chosen. In line with this suggestion, we ran two models in this study: one without any controls and the other one with controls, including participants' age, marital status, educational level, position, tenure, and organizational size. However, we found that the hypothesized relationships remained unchanged before and after adding control variables. As a result, we selected the SEM model without control variables as the final model, as it is a simpler and more parsimonious representation of the data.

3.3. Hypotheses testing

SEM was conducted using SPSS AMOS 26.0 software under Maximum Likelihood estimation. The hypothesized SEM model showed a good fit to the data as evidenced by the following fit indices: $\chi^2(483) = 1112.104$, $p < .001$; CFI = .953; TLI = .948; RMSEA = .058, 90% CI [.053, .062], $p < .01$; SRMR = .082.

The study tested several hypotheses (H1-H7) to examine the relationships between variables of interest. H1 predicted a positive relationship between supervisor verbal aggressiveness and perceived workgroup relationship conflict. Results indicated a positive and significant relationship ($\beta = .23$, $p < .01$), thus supporting H1. H2

Table 1
Sample Demographics (N = 392).

Respondent profiles	Frequency	Percentage
<i>Gender</i>		
Male	185	47.2%
Female	203	51.8%
Other	4	1%
<i>Race</i>		
White, not of Hispanic origin	277	70.7%
Hispanic	63	16.1%
Black or African American	52	13.3%
American Indian or Alaska Native	9	2.3%
Asian	20	5.1%
Native Hawaiian or Pacific Islander	1	0.3%
Other	1	0.3%
<i>Position</i>		
Non-management	204	52%
Lower-level management	51	13%
Middle-level management	93	23.7%
Top management	44	11.2%
<i>Education</i>		
No College (Secondary Education or below)	50	12.8%
Vocational Level (including Diploma, Higher Diploma and Associate Degree)	38	9.7%
Some College	86	21.9%
A Bachelor's Degree	120	30.6%
A Master's Degree	84	21.4%
A Doctoral Degree	14	3.6%
<i>Tenure</i>		
Less than 2 years	60	15.3%
2–5 years	116	29.6%
6–10 years	95	24.2%
11–15 years	28	7.1%
16–20 years	32	8.2%
More than 20 years	61	15.6%
<i>Organizational size</i>		
Less than 100	46	11.7%
100–249	71	18.1%
250–499	37	9.4%
500–999	59	15.1%
1000–2499	44	11.2%
2500–4999	34	8.7%
5000–9999	34	8.7%
10,000 or more	67	17.1%
<i>Industry sector</i>		
Banking and Finance	34	8.7%
Building and Construction	13	3.3%
Government/Public Administration	31	7.9%
Healthcare and Social Assistance	57	14.5%
Information Technology	23	5.9%
Manufacturing	37	9.4%
Real Estate and Rental and Leasing	3	0.8%
Arts, Entertainment and Recreation	1	0.3%
Accommodation and Food Service	16	4.1%
Agriculture, Forestry, Fishing and Hunting	2	0.5%
Professional, Scientific and Technical Services	20	5.1%
Educational Services	31	7.9%
Retail Trade	33	8.4%
Transportation and Warehousing	20	5.1%
Others	70	17.9%

expected a positive link between coworker verbal aggressiveness and perceived workgroup relationship conflict. This path was also positive and significant ($\beta = .33, p < .001$), and **H2 was supported**. H3 examined the relationship between perceived workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict. Results showed that perceived workgroup relationship conflict is positively linked to work-life conflict ($\beta = .55, p < .001$), **supporting H3**.

H4 and H5 explored the effects of supervisor and coworker verbal aggressiveness on employee work-life conflict. As revealed in the result, verbal aggressiveness was not directly associated with work-life conflict (H4: $\beta = .13, p = .11$; H5: $\beta = -.07, p = .43$), regardless of the initiator of verbal aggressiveness, thus **rejecting H4 and H5**. H6 proposed that work-life conflict is negatively related to employee-organization relationships. The result showed a significant and negative link ($\beta = -.27, p < .001$), **supporting H6**. H7 hypothesized a negative link between perceived workgroup relationship conflict and employee-organization relationships. This path was found to be negative ($\beta = -.18, p < .01$). **H7 was supported**.

Furthermore, the results revealed that the variance explained for workgroup relationship conflict is 28%, work-life conflict 35%, and employee-organization relationships 16%. Fig. 2 presents the hypothesized structural model with standardized path coefficients.

3.4. Post-hoc analysis

While not hypothesized, this study also examined the mediating role of workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict. Results showed that workgroup relationship conflict significantly mediated the effect of supervisor verbal aggressiveness ($\beta = .12, SE = .06, 95\% CI [.02, .24]$) and coworker verbal aggressiveness ($\beta = .18, SE = .06, 95\% CI [.07, .31]$) on employee work-life conflict. Additionally, work-life conflict was found to mediate the influence of workgroup relationship conflict on employee-organization relationships ($\beta = -.07, SE = .02, 95\% CI [-.12, -.03]$).

Furthermore, we tested whether workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict serve as serial mediators between workplace verbal aggressiveness and employee-organization relationships. The analysis revealed that the effect of supervisor verbal aggressiveness on employee-organization relationships is serially mediated by workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict ($\beta = -.02, SE = .008, 95\% CI [-.038, -.003]$). Similarly, workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict were found to serially mediate the relationship between coworker verbal aggressiveness and employee-organization relationships ($\beta = -.02, SE = .011, 95\% CI [-.053, -.008]$). In summary, the post-hoc analysis suggested that workplace verbal aggressiveness leads to perceived workgroup relationship conflict, which in turn, increases work-life conflict, and ultimately, deteriorates employee-organization relationship quality.

4. Discussion

While media attention has often focused on extreme cases of organizational aggression, such as physical assaults and workplace homicide,

Table 2
Composite reliability (CR), average variance extracted (AVE), Bivariate Correlations, Means, and Standard Deviations for the Main Variables (N = 392).

	CR	AVE	1	2	3	4	5
1. Supervisor verbal aggressiveness	0.95	0.79	0.89				
2. Coworker verbal aggressiveness	0.94	0.77	0.80***	0.88			
3. Workgroup relationship conflict	0.95	0.82	0.49***	0.51***	0.91		
4. Employee-organization relationship	0.97	0.88	-0.07	-0.04	-0.34***	0.94	
5. Work-life conflict	0.91	0.78	0.35***	0.33***	0.58***	-0.38***	0.88
<i>M</i>			2.03	2.11	2.24	3.65	2.47
<i>SD</i>			1.22	1.16	1.19	.93	1.27

***Correlation is significant at $p < .001$ (2-tailed).

The bolded numbers on the diagonal are the square roots of the AVE.

Table 3
Survey items and confirmatory factor analysis results.

Factors	Scale Items	Std. Loading	SE
Supervisor verbal aggressiveness	When others at work are very stubborn, my supervisor uses insults to soften their stubbornness.	.893	.037
	If individuals my supervisor is trying to influence really deserve it, my supervisor attacks their character.	.910	.037
	When people simply will not budge on a matter of importance, my supervisor loses temper and says rather strong things to them.	.886	.038
	When individuals insult my supervisor, my supervisor gets a lot of pleasure out of really telling them off.	.867	.040
	When nothing seems to work in trying to influence others, my supervisor yells and screams in order to get some movement from them.	.887	N.A.
	When others at work are very stubborn, my co-workers use insults to soften others' stubbornness.	.825	.045
	If an individual my co-workers are trying to influence really deserves it, my co-workers attack the individual's character.	.912	.041
Coworker verbal aggressiveness	When people simply will not budge on a matter of importance, my co-workers lose temper and say rather strong things to them.	.905	.041
	When individuals insult my co-workers, my co-workers get a lot of pleasure out of really telling people off.	.872	.043
	When nothing seems to work in trying to influence others, my co-workers yell and scream in order to get some movement from others.	.860	N.A.
	When I get home from work I am often too frazzled to participate in activities/responsibilities with my family/people I live with.	.869	N.A.
	I am often so emotionally drained when I get home from work that it prevents me from contributing to my family.	.916	.047
	Due to all the pressures at work, sometimes when I come home I am too stressed to do the things I enjoy.	.854	.049
	There is a lot of friction among employees in my department/unit.	.871	N.A.
Workgroup relationship conflict	There are a lot of personality conflicts in my department/unit.	.887	.040
	There is a lot of tension among employees in my department/unit.	.951	.038
	There is a lot of emotional conflict among employees in my department/unit.	.915	.039
	Whenever my organization makes an important decision, I know it will be concerned about people like me.	.500	N.A.
Employee-organization relationships	My organization can be relied on to keep its promises.	.863	.169
	I believe that my organization takes the opinions of people like me into account when making decisions.	.863	.181
	My organization has the ability to accomplish what it says it will do.	.728	.134
	I am happy with my organization.	.862	N.A.
	Both my organization and people like me benefit from the relationship.	.887	.042
	Most people like me are happy in their interactions with my organization.	.881	.043
		.904	.042

Table 3 (continued)

Factors	Scale Items	Std. Loading	SE
	Generally speaking, I am pleased with the relationship my organization has established with people like me.		
	I feel that my organization is trying to maintain a long-term commitment to people like me.	.919	N.A.
	I can see that my organization wants to maintain a relationship with people like me.	.931	.032
	There is a long-lasting bond between my organization and people like me.	.911	.033
	Compared with other organizations, I value my relationship with my organization more.	.865	.034
	My organization and people like me are attentive to what each other say.	.910	N.A.
	My organization believes that the opinions of people like me are legitimate.	.921	.035
	In dealing with people like me, my organization has a tendency to throw its weight around.	.356	.063
	My organization really listens to what people like me have to say.	.851	.040

most instances of workplace aggression are verbal in nature (Avtgis & Chory, 2010; Coombs & Holladay, 2004). Though verbal aggressiveness may not be as overt as other forms of aggression, it can still be highly detrimental to employees (Lybarger et al., 2017). This study investigated the negative effects of verbal aggressiveness, as demonstrated by supervisors and coworkers, on employees. The results revealed that supervisors' and coworkers' verbal aggressiveness was directly linked to employees' perception of workgroup relationship conflict, which subsequently led to increased work-life conflict and decreased employee-organization relationship quality. The key findings of the study, as well as their theoretical and practical implications, are discussed.

4.1. Influence of verbal aggressiveness on workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict

The current study revealed that verbal aggressiveness led to relationship conflict within the work group, which in turn, exacerbated employee perceptions of work-life conflict. These findings align with previous studies which have identified the negative impact of verbal aggressiveness on various physical and emotional outcomes such as decreased job motivation (Chory et al., 2020), organizational commitment (Madlock & Dillow, 2012), organizational assimilation (Sollitto & Cranmer, 2019), group cohesion (Anderson & Martin, 1999), and physical and mental health (Coombs & Holladay, 2004). Building on prior research, this study provides empirical evidence that workplace verbal aggressiveness from both supervisors and coworkers may result in intergroup relationship clashes. In other words, verbally aggressive language characterized by the use of profanity, maledictions, and nonverbal emblems can create or exacerbate conflicts and interpersonal issues within the work group (Jehn & Mannix, 2001).

An important finding of this study was that workgroup relationship conflict was found to be a significant antecedent of work-life conflict. Specifically, the more employees perceived tension and friction within their work groups, the more stress and strain they experienced in their personal lives. While there is a considerable amount of literature on the downstream effects of workgroup conflict, research has primarily focused on work-related outcomes such as decreased group creativity, group performance, member commitment, and increased turnover intentions (e.g., Bayazit & Mannix, 2003; De Dreu & Weingart, 2003; Farh et al., 2010). Using the framework of spillover theory (Staines, 1980)

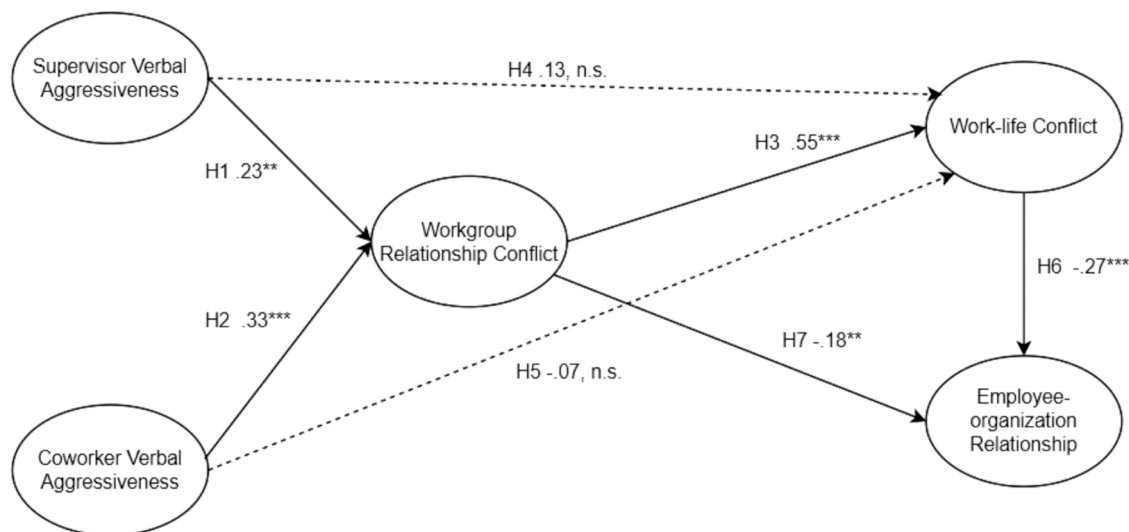


Fig. 2. The hypothesized structural model with standardized path coefficients. *** $p < .001$, ** $p < .01$, n.s. = non-significant.

and COR theory (Hobfoll, 1989), this study expanded the range of outcomes associated with workgroup relationship conflict by providing novel insights on how it can be viewed as a type of work-related stress that employees take home in the form of strain-based work-life conflict.

In addition to the direct association between workgroup relationship conflict and work-life conflict, this study also found an indirect influence of perceived workplace verbal aggressiveness on employee work-life conflict through workgroup relationship conflict. While there is a significant amount of evidence indicating that employees who are subjected to abuse may experience pressure and strain at home (Carlson et al., 2012; Eby et al., 2005), it is not as clear whether verbal aggressiveness, a more subtle and covert form of workplace aggression, would lead to work-life conflict. The existing literature also does not address the process through which verbal aggressiveness leads to work-life conflict. This study contributes to this line of research by demonstrating that workgroup relationship conflict can partially explain why and how workplace verbal aggressiveness negatively impacts work-life conflict. In other words, even though verbal aggressiveness may not have a direct influence on work-life conflict, managers and coworkers who use aggressive language are likely creating a hostile work environment, and the experience of workplace relationship conflicts would increase employee perceptions of work-life conflict.

4.2. Antecedents of employee-organization relationships

Finally, our findings contribute to a growing body of research on negative organizational factors that have been shown to harm employee-organization relationships (EORs). For example, previous studies have found that factors such as corporate ruthlessness (Men & Sung, 2022) and perceptions of organizational injustice (Lee, 2022) can damage EORs, as well as an authoritarian organizational culture (Kim et al., 2017). This study found a negative association between work-life conflict and EORs. This supports previous literature which suggests that the greater the work-life conflict, the more likely employees are to conclude that they are not being treated well by the organization (Liao, 2011; Siegel et al., 2005). As a result, employees will reciprocate accordingly, which in this case, leads to lower commitment, trust, and satisfaction with their organization. This finding is consistent with prior studies which have found that work-life conflict leads to low organizational trust, commitment, and job satisfaction (Gordon et al., 2007; Jiang, 2012; Kinnunen et al., 2004; Wright et al., 2014). Furthermore, this study adds to the literature that suggests that the positive feelings employees have in their work groups can affect their overall feelings about the organization (e.g., ; Ozcelik & Barsade, 2018; Wech et al.,

1998; Yue et al., 2022). Specifically, our findings showed that workgroup relationship conflict weakens employees' overall relationship quality with their organizations. This is also consistent with the idea that people interpret and explain their feelings and experiences in the context of the broader social units they are a part of, such as an organization (Lawler & Thye, 1999).

4.3. Theoretical contribution

Our findings contribute to internal communication and relationship management literature in three key ways. First, this study broadens the scope of internal communication research in public relations by identifying the "dark" side of internal communication. Previous research, with a few exceptions (e.g., Coombs & Holladay, 2004; Thelen, 2019; Welch, 2012), has primarily focused on identifying the positive aspects of internal communication and how it can lead to positive outcomes for employees and organizations. For example, research has shown that internal communication that is transparent, symmetrical, and empathetic can foster positive workplace outcomes (e.g., Jiang & Men, 2017; Kang & Sung, 2017; Kim, 2018; Lee & Li, 2020; Men, 2014; Walden et al., 2017; Yue et al., 2022). However, the effect of problematic workplace communication, such as verbal aggressiveness, which is prevalent and harmful in organizational contexts, has been largely overlooked. The current study addresses this research gap by examining the dark side of organizational life (Hunter et al., 2007). Negative events tend to last longer and have a more significant impact on a person's state of mind than positive events, known as negativity bias (Rook, 1998). By linking workplace verbal aggressiveness with negative workplace outcomes, we contribute to the growing conversation about the importance of investigating how "bad" communication may impact organizational success or failure. This is particularly relevant given the powerful and long-lasting impact that negative communication can have (Avtgis & Chory, 2010; Sollitto & Cranmer, 2019).

Second, this study contributes to internal communication literature by zooming in on the parallel influence of verbal aggressiveness from both a direct supervisor and coworkers. While previous research has recognized the importance of leadership and organizational communication, the role of coworker communication has been largely overlooked (Men & Bowen, 2017). However, as workplaces become more collaborative and decentralized, the influence of coworkers on employee satisfaction and job performance is becoming increasingly important (Jermier & Kerr, 1997; Fay & Kline, 2011; Silva & Sias, 2010). Thus, the current investigation advances the underexplored area of coworker communication by identifying the negative effects of coworker verbal

aggressiveness above and beyond a supervisor's influence.

Third, this study contributes to the body of knowledge in internal relationship management by proposing a new set of antecedents of EORs and providing a nuanced understanding of how workplace verbal aggressiveness negatively affects EORs. Previous research in this area has not adequately explored which organizational factors are particularly detrimental to EORs. This study addresses this gap by providing one of the earliest pieces of empirical evidence that the observation and/or experience of workplace verbal aggressiveness has a profound negative effect on EORs. Additionally, the study highlights the importance of considering workgroup dynamics and relationships when investigating organizations' internal relationship-building efforts. This is an important contribution as previous research has mainly focused on how perceptions of organizational-level strategies affect EORs, without considering the more direct influence of employees' workgroups (cf. Men, 2014; Walden et al., 2017). Finally, our findings corroborate with prior research (e.g., Jiang, 2012; Jiang & Men, 2017) that suggests employees' negative experiences in the family domain, caused by workplace verbal aggressiveness and workgroup relationship conflict, undermine their relationship-building process with employers. Overall, this study advances the theoretical connections between internal communication, work-life perception, and EORs.

4.4. Practical contribution

This study has several practical implications for organizations and internal public relations practitioners. First, this study suggests that inhibiting workplace verbal aggressiveness is as critical as fostering positive internal communication. Organizations should be mindful that verbal aggressiveness is not equivalent to the absence of effective communication practice; instead, it is a distinct behavior, the opposite of effective communication, that needs to be addressed and minimized to prevent long-term, negative consequences.

Second, internal public relations practitioners should actively monitor the level of intragroup relationship conflict and assess employees' work-life conflict as both are important predictors of employee-organization relationship quality. Furthermore, internal communication practitioners can make a valuable contribution to reducing workplace verbal aggressiveness. For instance, they can include assessments of verbal aggressiveness as part of the internal communication audits to monitor and identify the use of such language (Zwijze-Koning & de Jong, 2007). They can also direct organizational members who appear to have difficulty with verbal aggressiveness to assistance programs that focus on developing empathy and argumentation skills (Solitto & Cranmer, 2019). This can be particularly useful if verbal aggressiveness is found to be caused by a lack of rhetorical prowess or argumentative skill when expressing disagreements. (Kassing & Avtgis, 1999).

Finally, it is important to note that in many cases, leaders and other organizational members who exhibit high levels of verbal aggressiveness also demonstrate high levels of work competence. In such situations, these aggressors may not be sanctioned despite their inappropriate behavior (Namie & Lutgen-Sandvik, 2010). This may be due to organizational cultural beliefs that aggression is a means to success at all costs (Lutgen-Sandvik & Tracy, 2012). However, organizations should be aware that a toxic culture can lead to significant losses in trust, satisfaction, commitment, and control mutuality employees have towards the organization. Therefore, it is crucial that management does not dismiss subtle forms of workplace aggression. Public relations should collaborate with human resources to develop workplace policies and alter organizational culture, if possible, to ameliorate workplace aggression (Avtgis & Chory, 2010). Organizational members who consistently demonstrate verbal aggressiveness should be warned and sanctioned.

4.5. Limitations

This study has several limitations that should be taken into consideration. First, the study relied on self-reported data collected from employees, which may be subject to social desirability bias. To obtain more accurate results, future studies should consider collecting input from the target employees' coworkers and supervisors. For example, by aggregating scores from all team members, it would be possible to more objectively measure the level of relationship conflict within a workgroup. Additionally, participants' own verbal aggressiveness was not assessed despite the possibility that it might influence how they rate their supervisor or coworker's behavior. Gathering other team members' ratings of the supervisor's use of verbal language would contribute to the precision of the measurement.

Another limitation is the use of a cross-sectional research design, which prevents us from establishing causal relationships in the proposed model. Although the proposed relationships are grounded in theory and previous empirical research, there may be reciprocal relationships among the study variables. Findings from this study should be considered as a starting point for future research using longitudinal designs to discern the causal order among the study variables. Last, the generalizability and applicability of our findings is limited to the U.S. as participants were all U.S. workers. Therefore, future studies should consider a more diverse sample to test the generalizability of the findings.

4.6. Directions for future research

Given the prevalence of aggressive communication in contemporary organizations (Avtgis & Chory, 2010; Coombs & Holladay, 2004), future research should explore other forms of aggressive communication, such as argumentativeness and indirect interpersonal aggressiveness (Infante, 1987). Examining how argumentativeness, a constructive communication trait, affects employees' attitudes, behaviors, and perceptions of their relationship with their organization would be a valuable area of study. Additionally, studying indirect interpersonal aggressiveness, which refers to destructive communication acts that occur behind someone's back, may lead to a different set of outcomes compared to direct verbal aggressiveness. In conclusion, researchers should continue to uncover various forms of workplace aggressive communication and their associated impacts to expand the understanding of this topic.

Additionally, we recommend that communication scholars investigate the antecedents of supervisor and/or coworker verbal aggressiveness. Organizational culture, predispositions of aggressors, and organizational policies are notable causes that can be empirically investigated and verified (Avtgis & Chory, 2010). Understanding why bullies communicate aggressively is critical for informing organizational interventions that can ultimately stop this behavior.

Furthermore, future research should consider exploring the cascading effect of workplace verbal aggressiveness on employees' daily work behaviors, such as job engagement, work performance, and extra-role behaviors. Additionally, it would be beneficial to uncover whether there are interaction effects between supervisor and coworker communication on employee outcomes. Based on substitutes for leadership theory (Jermier & Kerr, 1997), it is possible that coworker behaviors may moderate the influence of leaders on followers.

Finally, we shed light on future research by investigating the implications of undesirable organizational practices, as negative events tend to have a greater impact on employee outcomes than positive ones (e.g., Madlock & Kennedy-Lightsey, 2010). Despite the fact that factors such as authoritarian culture and asymmetrical communication are widely recognized as being unethical and detrimental to public relations (e.g., Grunig, 2001; Sriramesh et al., 1996), little empirical research has been conducted in this area (see exception: Kim et al., 2017). We call on internal public relations scholars to investigate harmful organizational behaviors and their effects on employees and the success of public relations and organizations. The findings from this research can be

presented to management as concrete evidence of what practices to avoid.

5. Conclusion

Grounded in internal public relations and relationship management literature, this study proposed a conceptual model to examine the influence of workplace verbal aggressiveness on employee outcomes. Our findings indicated that the employment of verbal aggressiveness by coworkers and supervisors had a negative, indirect effect on the development of employee-organization relationships. More specifically, the perception of verbal aggressiveness within the workgroup led to intra-group relationship conflict, resulting in employee work-life conflict and eventually hindering their relationships with organizations as a whole. This research contributes to the understanding of negative communication behaviors in the workplace and expands existing knowledge on the factors that impede the development of quality employee-organization relationships.

Conflict of Interest

There is no conflict of interest to declare.

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